

Handset BATTLE

Lower tariffs and higher subscriptions attract new players to fight it out with MNCs with affordable and smart phones for a share of the booming Rs 50,000-crore market

By Malini Bhupta

If you've been dreaming of owning the latest touchscreen mobile phone but found the price prohibitive, you can now buy such a phone for just Rs 4,500. And the phone will come loaded with multimedia content to boot, so that you don't have to download the latest Bollywood songs. If you are willing to take the risk then there are a host of Indian brands that have come up with handsets offering interesting features and a slew of content. So the next time you go mobile shopping, don't be surprised to see handsets manufactured by well-known consumer brands like Videocon and Onida and new players like Intex, Micromax and Karbonn vying for attention on the shelves.

The market now looks very interesting from a business point of view

as Indians are buying 10-12 million phones every month, adding up to Rs 50,000 crore per annum in revenues. While Nokia is still the leader and sells close to five million phones a month, the rest of the market is split between other international and domestic brands. Given that each month, telecom companies are adding on 12 to 15 million connections, both handset makers and mobile service providers are seeing growth. Unlike in the past, mobile phone makers are not waiting for long, but launching new models and variants in India every few months as the market here is very dynamic.

Ever since mobile phones became the rage in India, consumers have either opted for branded phones by multinationals (MNCs) or the cheap Chinese phones in the grey market. In



Karbonn

It is a joint venture between Delhi-based Jaina Group that distributes HTC mobile phones in India and South Asia, and Bangalore-based UTL Group.

Price range **Rs 2,000 to Rs 7,000**

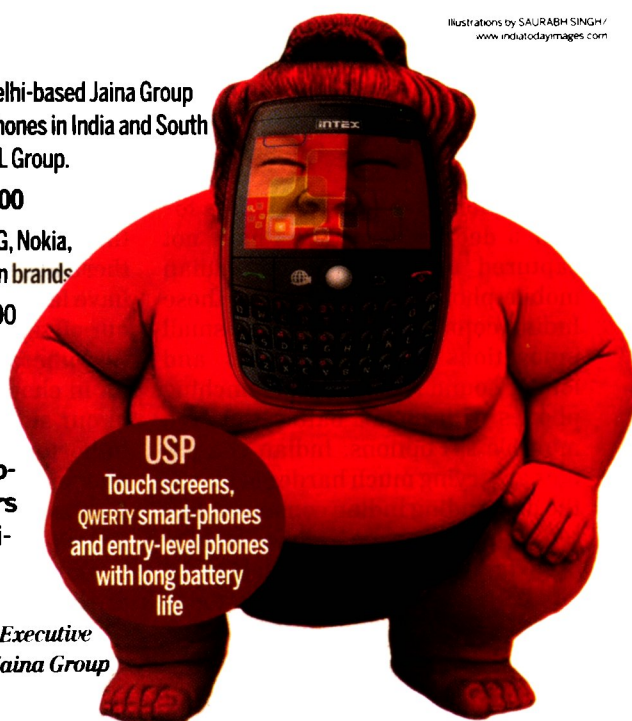
Competes against Samsung, LG, Nokia, Sony Ericsson and other Indian brands

Reach Available through 50,000 outlets across the country.

Plans to establish 5-10 exclusive Karbonn mobile stores.

"We are looking at providing rural consumers with a complete multimedia experience at affordable prices."

SHASHIN DEVASARE, *Executive Director, Jaina Group*



Illustrations by SAURABH SINGH/
www.indiatodayimages.com

USP
Touch screens,
QWERTY smart-phones
and entry-level phones
with long battery
life

Intex

A 13-year-old IT hardware, mobile phones and electronics company headquartered in Delhi

Price range **Rs 2,200 to Rs 10,000**

Competes against Samsung, LG, Sony Ericsson and other Indian brands

Reach Routed through a channel network of 12,000+ dealers spread across the country. The company has launched five exclusive retail outlets by the name of Intex Square in Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh.

"We launched a dust and waterproof phone in 2008, making it more steady for the rural consumer."

RAMESH VASWANI, *Executive Vice-Chairman, Intex Mobile*

USP
Dual and triple SIM
phones with QWERTY
keypad, Java application
and expandable memory
up to 4 GB